

STRAY DOG OF ANIME

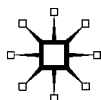


*The Films of
Mamoru Oshii*

SECOND EDITION

BRIAN RUH

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STRAY DOG OF ANIME
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CHAPTER SIX

GHOST IN THE SHELL (1995)

ALTHOUGH OSHII'S REPUTATION AS A VISIONARY director continued to grow through the early 1990s, he was still unmistakably a part of the commercial anime industry. Specifically, he worked closely with the company Bandai, whose various subsidiaries produce video games, toys, and animation. Oshii had been working on another anime project for Bandai between the two *Patlabor* films, but the company suddenly canceled it. Said Oshii, "I was so upset that I asked Bandai if I could direct something else, and they said 'Do whatever you want.'"¹ With Bandai's blessing, Oshii directed *Talking Head* (1992), his personal meditation on the art and industry of film and animation. Although the film sometimes is billed as a mix of live action and anime, the animation does not occupy very much screen time (and only a very small bit of animation at the beginning is in what has come to be accepted as the anime style). Like Oshii's other live action films before *Avalon* (*The Red Spectacles* and *Stray Dog: Kerberos Panzer Cops*, which are discussed briefly in chapter 7), the style of *Talking Head* is very different from that of his animated films. *Talking Head* takes on an obvious staged form, drawing from both Japanese and Western styles, with most of the action taking place

as if in a play. In true Oshii fashion, the end reveals that most of the film's events had been dreamed by the main character.

Bandai also was responsible for Oshii's involvement in *Ghost in the Shell*, the film for which the director became best known around the world. After completing work on *Patlabor 2*, Oshii consulted with Bandai Visual about what direction to take with his next project. Originally he was planning to direct an OVA series based on his manga *Kenroh Densetsu* (released by Dark Horse Comics in English as *Hellhounds: Panzer Cops*), set in the same universe as his previous live-action films *The Red Spectacles* (1987) and *Stray Dog: Kerberos Panzer Cops* (1991). Instead, Bandai suggested that Oshii next work on their proposed adaptation of the manga *Ghost in the Shell*. His work on the two *Patlabor* films situated him perfectly to work on this film, as the plot coincided with many of the themes he had been pursuing. Although he had not created the story on which the film was based, Oshii managed to make the work his own; original manga author Masamune Shirow gave him permission to reformulate the plot as he saw fit. Oshii said that he was given the license to direct the film "in my own style, with my own ideas. . . . I had the freedom to put *Ghost* into my world, without having to further ask his [Shirow's] approval."² With its mix of concerns about technology and the nature of reality, the *Ghost in the Shell* manga was perfect for adaptation by Oshii. Although largely excised from the film version, the original manga contained a good deal of political critique, and dialogue like "Emphasizing a lifestyle based on consumption is the *ultimate* violence against poor countries"³ made the source material a good thematic fit with Oshii's previous work in *Patlabor 2*.

As a manga artist, *Ghost in the Shell* creator Shirow is unique in both style and production. Many manga titles are drawn quickly to meet tight deadlines. In contrast, Shirow's manga is very detailed, with complex lines and an equally complex plot. Unlike other manga artists, many of whom employ a stable of staffers to meet publication demands, Shirow draws all of his art himself. In fact, he is something of an enigma; no publicity pictures of the artist exist, and his name is a pseudonym. He made his debut

in 1983 with the serialization in a fanzine of his manga *Black Magic*, which was later reissued by a professional publisher; this again sets Shirow apart from most manga artists, who often make their professional debuts through a system of serialization in manga magazines, rather than a repackaging of their amateur work. Shirow also works from his studio in Kobe, rather than the cultural and publishing capital of Tokyo, where most manga artists are based. Like Oshii, Shirow trained at college to become an art teacher, but unlike the film director, Shirow taught at the high school level before he devoted himself to his manga career full time. Shirow's manga display a love of sleek technology and beautiful women. One of the most common motifs in his manga, and especially in his illustration work, is that of sexy women (often youthful and scantily clad) posing with futuristic military weaponry. However, the fetishized feminine forms of his artwork belie the detailed and intelligent plots of his manga.

One of the highlights of the film version of *Ghost in the Shell* is its extensive use of computer graphics, emphasizing the trend of pushing the animation of the unreal in more realistic directions. Said animation director Toshihiko Nishikubo, "*Ghost in the Shell* was the first in animation to explore reality to the limit. We aimed to create animation that is more real than life."⁴ Hiroyuki Yamaga, director of the anime *The Wings of Honneamise* (*Oneamisu no Tsubasa*, 1987), has suggested that his film actually began the trend in realistic animation which was later picked up by directors such as Katsuhiro Ōtomo (dir. *Akira*, 1988) and Oshii.⁵ By making animation behave more like live cinema, these recent trends in anime serve to make the realities of the directors' imagined worlds more believable. Additionally, the sophisticated computer graphics used in the production of a film like *Ghost in the Shell* mirror the story's commentary on how the increasing use of technology is impacting our everyday lives.

Although *Ghost in the Shell* reportedly played for only four weeks after opening in Tokyo, the film did substantially better in the United States, rising to the number-one position on the *Billboard* sales charts after a moderately successful art house theatrical run.⁶ At the time, it garnered more

attention in the Western media than any previous anime film, save perhaps *Akira*. *Ghost in the Shell* has become one of the most analyzed anime films by Western academics. For better or for worse it has become an ambassador abroad for Japanese animated film.

CHARACTERS

MAJOR MOTOKO KUSANAGI—The main character of *Ghost in the Shell*, Kusanagi is a government operative in a secretive branch called Section 9. She is a cyborg and very feminine in appearance; her body is almost entirely artificial, yet there remains, in theory, an organic core of brain matter in her skull. The main plot of the film involves Kusanagi's pursuit of the mysterious entity known as the Puppet Master.

THE PUPPET MASTER—Also known as Project 2501, the Puppet Master is an artificial life-form that evolved on the Net from a government program. It seeks out Kusanagi as a kindred being, as it is searching for a way to evolve and needs Kusanagi's assistance to do so.

BATOU—Another member of Section 9, Batou is a large, masculine cyborg. Not only Kusanagi's work associate, he is also her only friend, showing genuine concern for her well-being even outside of the work environment.

ARAMAKI—"Old man" Aramaki is the chief of Section 9, and as such is involved in the internal politics of subterfuge that are inherent in such a governmental position. He is Kusanagi's direct supervisor.

SYNOPSIS

A lone figure crouches atop a large skyscraper, the fluorescent city teeming with life below her. Motoko Kusanagi and the rest of her team in the special government division of Section 9 are in the process of assassinating

a visiting foreign official. To pull off the hit, Kusanagi secures herself to the top of the high-rise in which the dignitary is covertly meeting with a secretive computer programmer. Kusanagi removes most of her clothing (she still wears a skintight flesh-colored suit) and lets herself fall down the side of the building. In a suite inside, the official and computer programmer are discussing something called Project 2501. Police burst into the room from the main part of the building, at which point the diplomat claims immunity and tries to talk his way out of his predicament. Kusanagi's secured cord stops her at just the right floor. She opens fire with a high-powered machine gun and the official's body explodes in a haze of blood. As Kusanagi continues her descent toward the ground, she activates her "thermoptic camouflage," slowly fading into the background of the city below until nothing more can be seen of her.

After the opening credits, during which the audience is shown a montage detailing the assembly of the cyborg Kusanagi, it is learned that the prime minister's translator has been "ghost hacked." (The film never explains what a "ghost" is, but it seems to be akin to the concept of the soul, although it is something physical that can be detected in a computer scan.) This ghost can be accessed through the electronic lines of data connectivity that serve to link nearly everyone and everything in this future world. The hacking is believed to be the work of the Puppet Master, a cyberterrorist who has caused chaos throughout the world, and Kusanagi and the rest of the members of Section 9 are sent to track him down. After a pursuit involving a garbage truck and a foot chase through crowded city streets, the culprit turns out to be a mere pawn of the Puppet Master. The Puppet Master had erased the man's memory and implanted false memories; even with the advanced medical technology of the time, the implantation of such memories is irreversible.

Taking some personal time off, Kusanagi goes diving in the ocean, an experience that she says always conjures many different emotions in her. As she and her partner Batou sit on the deck of their small boat drinking beer, they both hear the same voice, saying "For now we see through a glass,

darkly" (a biblical quote from the book of Corinthians). Although they try to dismiss what they both think they heard, the mysterious voice haunts them. Kusanagi begins to talk about the things that give rise to her concept of self. She says that such things as a face, a voice, "memories of childhood," "feelings for the future," and "the extent of the data net," while components of self, also "simultaneously confine [her] within set limits." Although she is a powerful cyborg, she is constrained by the structures of power around her; even though stating she is free to quit Section 9 at any time she chooses, she would be forced to return her cyborg body and the memories contained within. (In this way, the film asserts that Kusanagi is more than just a mental "ghost" inhabiting her mechanical cyborg shell and says that the mind is inexorably linked with the body.)

On a dark, rainy evening, a nude female cyborg torso is brought into Section 9. The conditions surrounding its arrival are highly suspect: A cyborg-producing factory had started up on its own and produced just one body, which got up and left the factory, but subsequently was hit by a truck on the highway and severely damaged. The operatives of Section 9 discover that the inhabitant of the artificial body is none other than the Puppet Master, who claims to be an artificial entity created from a government program on the Net. Because it has achieved sentience, it is now a fugitive from the government and requests political asylum. However, before a decision can be made or a statement taken, other government agents attack Section 9 and abscond with the cyborg torso. Kusanagi and the other Section 9 members follow the captors, yet Kusanagi alone attempts to retrieve the torso. Her goal is not to bring the torso back to Section 9, but rather to "dive" into it, to communicate freely and deeply with the Puppet Master, whom she believes holds the key to her understanding of self because it is a self-evolved being.

Kusanagi tracks the abductors to a museumlike structure in a crumbling, flooded part of the city, in which she finds a multilegged armored tank. To get to the Puppet Master she has to try to defeat the tank by herself, playing a game of cat-and-mouse among the pillars of the building. As it tracks Kusanagi, the tank's guns rake across skeletal images of what appear

to be large ancient fish on the walls, obliterating them into large pockmarks and shrapnel. One of the most striking scenes of the film is when the tank's firing guns follow Kusanagi up a staircase and continue going up the image at the top of the stairs, a picture of a tree of life painted on the museum walls. The holes in the image continue to climb until the tank runs out of ammunition just shy of the pinnacle of the tree, labeled with the Latin word "hominis."

Kusanagi scrambles atop the tank and tries to force the hatch open, but she ends up ripping her cybernetic body apart in the process. Just as one of the tank's arms has her in a death grip, Batou arrives with an antitank rifle, which stops the hulking machine. As there are no current threats, Kusanagi decides to interface directly with the Puppet Master's cyberbrain. With Batou's help, she is connected to the intelligence residing within the hijacked cyborg torso, and she begins a dialogue with it. As they converse, unmarked helicopters fly toward their location, carrying snipers intent on destroying both the Puppet Master and Kusanagi.

The Puppet Master tells Kusanagi that it has been watching her for a long time and that it needs to try to evolve by merging with her. As an artificial life-form, the Puppet Master lacks the capability for the type of reproduction that engenders variation and serves as protection from extinction. Both of them will change, the Puppet Master says, but such change is necessary for survival. He tells Kusanagi, "Your desire to remain as you are is what ultimately limits you." As Kusanagi sees what appears to be the silhouette of an angel descending from the sky, the snipers on the helicopters are able to target both her and the Puppet Master's body. The Puppet Master is destroyed, but Batou is able to save Kusanagi's head from the incoming fire, although it is blown clear from the rest of her body. As Section 9's helicopters chase away the unknown, Batou rushes to salvage Kusanagi's functioning remains.

In Batou's personal safe house, Kusanagi wakes up in the mechanical body of a young girl. Batou apologizes for the body, saying it was all he could find on the black market with such short notice. He goes on to explain that

the situation has been officially covered up but that the foreign minister has been forced to resign and the event has ended in a political stalemate. Smiling, Batou says that the only thing the government does not know is what happened to Kusanagi's cyberbrain. As Kusanagi gets up to leave, she mentions the biblical quote she and Batou had heard the other evening, saying that the preceding lines were "When I was a child, I spake as a child. I understood as a child, I thought as a child. But when I became a man, I put away childish things." Kusanagi says she is now neither the Puppet Master nor the same woman who used to be known as Kusanagi. As she walks out into the night, she looks out over the city, wondering to where she should now go, concluding "The Net is vast and limitless."

COMMENTARY AND ANALYSIS

Patlabor 2 questioned the nature of reality through an analysis of the ways in which it is constantly mediated, examining many ideas typical of the cyberpunk genre of literature and film. Not until *Ghost in the Shell* did Oshii create a film that fully fleshed out many of these ideas. His film is a meditation on the nature of the self in the digital age, depicting how we may in the future (and to some extent do now) construct our personal identities.

As science fiction writer Bruce Sterling stated, "[c]ertain central themes spring up repeatedly in cyberpunk. The theme of body invasion: prosthetic limbs, implanted circuitry, cosmetic surgery, genetic alteration. The even more powerful theme of mind invasion: brain-computer interfaces, artificial intelligence, neurochemistry—techniques radically defining the nature of humanity, the nature of the self."⁷ Such cyberpunk themes are present as crucial visual elements in *Ghost in the Shell*. Although cyberpunk originally was a mid-1980s Western literary movement, its ideas spread rather quickly through Japan, and the novels of genre archetype-setter William Gibson were especially popular.⁸ The Japanese interest in cyberpunk is an intriguing cultural reversal, as many American cyberpunk authors incorporated

Japanese words or cultural concepts in their works, most notably Gibson in his book *Neuromancer* (1984), one of the best representatives of the cyberpunk literary genre. By incorporating such references, Japan was made to be the battleground on which the conflict between antiquated tradition and technological modernity would play out in the popular consciousness. In his film Oshii is able to use this idea of a technologized Asia to his advantage.

The world of *Ghost in the Shell* is international in scope, an aspect inherent in the original manga and one that corresponds with trends in cyberpunk fiction. (Japan loomed large in the minds of many cyberpunk writers, but it was far from the only locale.) Manga artist Shirow said his original work can “transcend national boundaries. Even native speakers may have different reactions to the multiple meanings I’ve built into the story through the Japanese characters.”⁹ The story itself, and the production of the film, reflect its international nature. *Ghost in the Shell* was partially financed by the American-based Manga Entertainment and, according to Manga CEO Marvin Gleicher, was the first Japanese anime film to be partially funded from outside Japan.¹⁰ Additionally, the crew traveled to Guam to study the firing characteristics of machine guns and other heavy arms. (Such weapons are illegal in Japan.) The urban locale at the heart of the story was transposed from the fictional Japanese metropolis of Newport City in the manga to an unnamed East Asian sprawl in the film version that bears a striking resemblance to Hong Kong. At the same time, though, Oshii has downplayed the international scope of *Ghost in the Shell*, and anime in general, saying, “I doubt if there’s ever been a Japanese animation produced with the Western audience in mind. I certainly never directed any of my animations thinking about how these might be received in the West.”¹¹

Cyberpunk and East Asia have not always had an easy relationship. Beginning with *Neuromancer*, cyberpunk literature has tended to fetishize Asia, and Japan in particular. One plausible explanation is that in the latter half of the twentieth century, Japan became the locus for all things high tech. For example, the September 2001 issue of the technology and cyberculture magazine *Wired* bore the image of a computer-generated cute female

image—perhaps Kusanagi by way of Sanrio—with technological accoutrements such as cell phone, headset, and a suit that looked like it was made of liquid metal. Bearing the statement “Japan Rocks” superimposed on the technofemale image, the issue contained a special section on Japan whose key question, posed in the title for the introduction to the section, was “Is Japan still the future?” Headlining the section is a piece by William Gibson examining whether Tokyo is still the “futurologically sexy” place about which he wrote in his cyberpunk novels of the 1980s.¹² A subsequent piece, entitled “Ten Reasons Why the Sun Still Rises in the East,” briefly details how such things as industrial design, architecture, robotics, comics, video-games, erotica, and game shows make Japan a global pop culture trendsetter.¹³ Such articles show how in modern media the idea of Japan is closely tied into the idea of futuristic technology. In the early 1990s David Morley and Kevin Robins wrote that “[t]he association of technology and Japanese-ness now serves to reinforce the image of a culture that is cold, impersonal and machine-like, an authoritarian culture lacking emotional connection to the rest of the world.”¹⁴ The Orientalism of old was an exoticizing and totalizing mind-set, viewing Japan solely in terms of manifestations like Zen and tea ceremony; this new Orientalism, or Techno-Orientalism, involves Japan’s relation to the products and processes of technology. According to Toshiya Ueno, a frequent commentator on Techno-Orientalism and anime, “In Techno-Orientalism, Japan is not only located geographically, as Jean Baudrillard once said, as a satellite in orbit, but also projected chronologically by being located in the future of technology.”¹⁵ Techno-Orientalism is the West’s fetishization of an imagined technological Japan.

In analyzing *Ghost in the Shell*, it is especially important to keep the ideas of Orientalism and Techno-Orientalism in mind. Because Oshii’s films address the intertwined issues of the spirit and technology, some may misinterpret a discussion of these films as falling into a Techno-Orientalist trap. For example, Ueno says of Antonia Levi’s book on Japanese animation, *Samurai from Outer Space*: “Her analysis implies that *anime* is more interesting for ‘western’ people than for the Japanese because of its cultural specificity.

The Orientalism reappears when she insists that in Japanese animation, traditional or ancient mythology is very significant, so that *anime* is assumed to be closely connected to cultural identity in Japan.”¹⁶ Here Ueno asserts that by closely examining how religion is referenced and reformulated in anime, one is necessarily expressing an Orientalist mind-set; I do not believe this to be the case. By analogy, some people might perceive my present discussion of Oshii’s films as being part of the Orientalist and Techno-Orientalist strains of thought. However, the converse of Ueno’s criticism of Levi is that mythology is not significant in anime, an odd assertion given the extensive mythological references in anime. Similarly, mythology must be viewed as significant in Oshii’s films because he refers to it so extensively. To ignore the culturally specific tropes in anime is to omit completely an entire level of meaning.

Such critiques also miss how the Japanese are responsible for the propagation of Techno-Orientalist formulations of themselves in the West. The Japanese government’s White Paper for the year 2000, called “Japanese Government Policies in Education, Science, Sports and Culture,” states that “Japanese animation is a fine and unique form of expression due to the techniques of Japanese artists, and there are high expectations for it in the future.”¹⁷ Thus, the Japanese government is promulgating anime as a representation of Japan to the world and a cultural export of note. If, as Ueno suggests, anime “is defined by the stereotype of Japan as . . . an image of the future,”¹⁸ then the Japanese government is complicit in perpetuating such stereotypes. This Japan-originated Techno-Orientalism also can be seen through the book *Inside the Robot Kingdom: Japan, Mechatronics, and the Coming Robotopia* by Frederik L. Schodt, an author who has, not coincidentally, written some of the best English-language resources on Japanese comics. Early in the book, Schodt comments, “The Japanese people often refer to their nation as *robotto okoku*, or ‘the Robot Kingdom,’”¹⁹ implying that at least certain elements of Techno-Orientalism are of Japanese construction. It is also telling that the publisher of Schodt’s investigation of the Japanese robot was Kodansha, a Japanese publishing house. It could be

argued that because of his emphasis on technology, Oshii is contributing to formulations of Techno-Orientalism. Many of his films contain a high level of technical detail; for example, the crew of *Ghost in the Shell* took firearms training in Guam in order to more realistically animate the functioning and firing of such weapons. Some of Oshii's films, as we have seen, are set in a not-too-distant future and contain many examples of futuristic technology such as giant robots, cyborgs, artificial life, and virtual reality. However, these films thoroughly question and problematize the presence of such technology. For a Japanese director investigating questions of technology in society, the specter of Techno-Orientalism threatens to overshadow the work at hand.

It must be admitted, though, that examining this fictionalized Japan can provide insights into how we can and should relate to technology in our daily lives. In *Ghost in the Shell*, Oshii provides many symbolic examples of such technological interactions. In the film's look and feel, he is returning to the rich imagery of the film *Angel's Egg* he created nearly ten years earlier. Oshii incorporated some of the visuals and themes of *Angel's Egg* into his adaptation of *Ghost in the Shell*. Although *Ghost in the Shell* is a more technologically sophisticated film, many of the core elements remain the same. *Ghost in the Shell* uses Christian imagery and quotations from the Bible to question the meaning of individual identity and of reality. Perhaps most striking are the similarities in the setting of the climaxes of both films. Both occur in a mysterious building containing the skeletal remains of giant creatures. Also present in both films is a large stylized tree on one interior wall of the building. In *Angel's Egg* the tree makes the soldier remember the great, terrible bird he thinks he once saw, in *Ghost in the Shell* the tree symbolizes the evolution of life itself.

Toward the climax of *Ghost in the Shell*, the use of sophisticated weaponry that destroys both the images of the skeletal fish and the tree in the museum is symbolic of a sense of loss created by the encroachment of technology. If the tank had more ammunition, it would have destroyed the "hominis" label on the tree as well, alluding to the fact that we modern

humans are more than capable of orchestrating our own destruction. This scene is illustrative of Oshii's problematization of technology—in one way, we are killing ourselves and our past through technology's sheer drive forward, but in another way (as we shall see), successful negotiation of relationships with technology can potentially open powerful avenues of freedom.

Another allegorical scene in *Ghost in the Shell* is the opening, in which Kusanagi is ordered to assassinate a diplomat. The scene is not long, yet it introduces many of the key issues explored throughout the film. When the diplomat's body explodes, we can see, in addition to the expected internal organs and spinal column, a network of cords and plugs, showing in the brief flash that the man was in fact a cyborg. He may look like a "normal" human on the surface, but he is in fact an amalgam, a merger of blood and microchips. We also can see, as Kusanagi shoots, that the giant fish tank in the room was not real either but merely a hologram; as Kusanagi's bullets shatter the wall, what appeared to be a fish tank does not explode and shower the room with water, but rather goes black like a dead television and fractures like glass. In an attempt to hit Kusanagi, the police in the room shoot out the rest of the fish tank screens in the room, ruining the remainder of the illusion. In less than ten seconds, we are shown that both the man and the fish, whose presence we did not question, owed their existences to technology.

This first scene shows Oshii playing with ideas of mediated knowledge and structures of power. In the *Patlabor* films, he often showed the distortion and alteration of points of view by depicting scenes through various camera lenses and monitors. The world of *Ghost in the Shell* is even more mediated than that of *Patlabor*, and Oshii shows that with the increasing prevalence of technology, even a "direct" apprehension of the world is subject to illusions, such as the holographic fish tank, the cyborg nature of the diplomat, and Kusanagi's thermoptic camouflage. Such mediation of the visual image is indicative of an apparent domination of reality by the forces that control such media structures. In the case of Kusanagi, the system of control is the government for which she works. She is portrayed as being

very powerful, but she can use the power only at the behest of her employer, not for her own freedom.

That Kusanagi is subject to control is shown during the credit sequence, which illustrates her assembly. The process of constructing Kusanagi indicates her confinement within her own body. Her organic brain is scanned and placed into a casing that is in turn enclosed by a mechanical skull. Her artificial musculature is covered by a metal skin and coated with a synthetic epidermis. Finally (although this is not explicitly shown), she is inserted into a hierarchy in which she has little choice but to participate, as the government can use her body against her as a prison for her mind. However, Kusanagi is able to find release, not by overcoming the confines of the body, but rather through the further blurring of the mind/body and organic/artificial dichotomies.

The original manga written by Masamune Shirow differs in a number of respects from Oshii's film. The plot involving the Puppet Master was not the only story in the manga, although it was a pivotal one; Oshii chose to focus on this one particular story arc to give the film a better-defined focus than the sprawling manga. Oshii's Kusanagi is a much lonelier character than the one in the manga. She is given to long periods of solitary contemplation, often in conjunction with images of water, such as diving in the harbor. Oshii also uses the film to further his use of the basset hound as a visual trope; it was not a part of the original manga. The dog first appears when Kusanagi and Batou are chasing the man who had been trying to ghost-hack the translator—the man runs in front of a wall mosaicked with posters featuring a basset hound. Later, as the police debrief the hacker, the camera transitions to a television commercial involving the same dog that had been on the posters. The police then show the man the photograph he had been trying to show his partner of his wife and kids; it turns out it is a photo of him with a dog—again a basset hound. The image of the lonely and contemplative Kusanagi and the basset hound are brought together later during a canal cruise. As Kusanagi looks around, observing the detritus of the city, she sees a basset hound on a pedestrian walkway above her, looking down

at the water. In a world nearly devoid of friendly human interaction, the recurring basset hound is a reassuring reminder of the foundation of human existence.

Additionally, the film places less emphasis on forthright sexuality than the manga. In the manga, Kusanagi is given a “cuter” character design, with frequent emphasis on the curves of her body. Character designer and key animation supervisor Hiroyuki Okiura says of the film version of Kusanagi that she “is a cyborg. Therefore her body is very strong and youthful. However, her human mentality is considerably older than she looks. I tried to depict this maturity in her character instead of making her younger like the original girl created by Masamune Shirow.”²⁰ Kusanagi has a boyfriend in the original manga and is seen (in a segment edited out of the U.S. release) participating in a virtual lesbian orgy. Although the film version of *Ghost in the Shell* retains a number of instances of female nudity, it is not as exploitative as the original, and actually serves to foster Oshii’s mythic ideas.

A number of writings on *Ghost in the Shell*, from both academic and nonacademic sources, have commented on the apparent nudity present in the film. Although Kusanagi is a very powerful female character, this use of nudity has been viewed as weakening her by depicting her body in a sexualized fashion. Author Carl Silvio postulates that the film “appears at first sight to subvert radically the power dynamics inherent in dominant structures of gender and sexual difference, while covertly reinscribing them.”²¹ Thus an examination of nudity in the film is essential because the use of sexualized images of the body is one way that strong female protagonists have sometimes been subverted in popular cinema. The body is an important unit of control, and by observing Kusanagi as both an erotic figure and a mother figure, her body becomes a personalized form of control within herself.

According to Silvio’s analysis, any look at the female body is both eroticized and undermining. For example, he describes the scene on the boat in which Kusanagi removes her wetsuit as “Botau [*sic*], with mouth agape, looking at her, followed by a quick reverse shot back to Kusanagi, the object of his gaze.”²² This account is a mischaracterization of the scene, however,

as Batou does not actively look at Kusanagi, but instead turns away when he notices she is changing. Silvio also takes issue with Kusanagi's creation scene during the opening credits and her use of thermoptic camouflage, calling the film's attention to her body "obsessive objectification."²³ One reason for this attitude may be the misperception of Kusanagi as being nude in a number of scenes in which she is actually wearing the flesh-tone bodysuit that serves as a blank canvas for her thermoptic camouflage. The only instances of nudity in the film are in Kusanagi's creation scene, when looking at the torso of the embodied Puppet Master, and at the very end, when Kusanagi's bodysuit has been torn away. This nudity stems not from a position of weakness, but rather serves to mark such scenes as periods of transition in Kusanagi's life. The first scene shows the process of Kusanagi's creation and details her "birth." Nudity in such a context should not be interpreted as necessarily being sexual, but rather portrays the cyborg Kusanagi as more human. The nude scene at the end of the film brings the creation metaphor full circle; she is exiting her life (or rather that period of her life as "Major Kusanagi") in the same state in which she entered it. Also, Kusanagi's nudity here is appropriate; it can be seen as an outward sign of her intimacy with the nude torso of the Puppet Master. Thus, Oshii's use of nudity subverts the sexuality of the original manga, which presented the sexualized fetishization of the female body.

Another critique of Kusanagi's representation in the film is that she is weakened by her depiction as a maternal being. In *Technologies of the Gendered Body*, Anne Balsamo analyzes a *LIFE* magazine article that details the possible artificial replacement parts for the body of the future. The image of this future person, however, is obviously gendered as male, complete with artificial nonfunctional testicle and lacking any reference to one of the few prostheses that actually was available at the time, the breast implant. Balsamo goes on to say that "[i]n this future vision, the male body is marked by the sign of a full-bodied person whereas the female body is marked only by an artificial uterus; such significations offer an ominous warning about the imaginary place of women in the technological future."²⁴ Thus, the coding

of Kusanagi as an “artificial uterus” of sorts, bearing the Puppet Master’s offspring into the Net, must initially be regarded with suspicion.

In her analysis of the female in Japanese religion, Yuko Nakano writes that “[m]any Japanese men have what could almost be called a kind of religious feeling about motherhood, or are caught up by the image.”²⁵ This could account for why Oshii, as a man, has the Puppet Master (whose artificial voice certainly sounds masculine) code Kusanagi as the bearer of their offspring when discussing their pending union. This joining of the Puppet Master and Kusanagi has religious overtones as well; it can allude to the “virgin birth” of Christianity as well as a similar belief in Shintō whereby a *kami* (a god) “might possess a pure and holy virgin and that she might become aware of this divine power and give birth to a child of the *kami*.”²⁶ However, like all elements of control in his films, Oshii does not use this image of the mother in a customary way, but rather subverts it. Kusanagi, while she may in a sense be the “mother” to the new being she becomes, does not take up the standard social role of the mother in society. Instead, at the end of the film, we see Kusanagi contemplating the vastness of the Net, implying that she will be going out into society as she always has done rather than becoming focused on home and family. There is nothing inherently weakening or discriminatory about being a mother; the social role such a person may occupy is, however. Oshii eschews this categorization and in the process shows Kusanagi as liberated from dualistic roles of man/machine and mind/body.

Deepening the themes Oshii conveys in *Ghost in the Shell* are his allusions to many varieties of religion, including Buddhism, Shintō, and Christianity. For example, the lyrics for the main theme song of the film were composed in the ancient Yamato language and speak of a god descending from the heavens. The song displays a strong Shintō influence and can be seen as alluding to the descent of the Japanese sun goddess Amaterasu, who is the mythological source of Japanese civilization.²⁷ Again, *Ghost in the Shell* depicts the female as being a source of strength, culture, and empowerment.

Another religious metaphor is the use of imagery involving falling, alluding to mankind’s initial fall from grace as depicted in the Bible. Susan

J. Napier has detailed these falls in *Ghost in the Shell*: They include the fall from the skyscraper at the beginning of the film immediately prior to the assassination attempt, the metaphorical fall involved in diving in the harbor (after which Kusanagi hears the Puppet Master quote a line from the book of Corinthians to her), and finally her fall into the mind of the Puppet Master at the climax of the film.²⁸ These falls initially may be construed as a biblical “fall from grace,” but in fact Oshii uses the idea of the fall in a much more sophisticated way. In his historical analysis of the Bible, Bernard Batto states that the biblical story of the fall “is not a story of a ‘fall’ from original perfection at all. Quite the contrary, it is a story about *continuously improved* creation.”²⁹ Thus through Kusanagi’s series of “falls,” we can see her as improving, finally reaching an apogee through her merger with the Puppet Master—another example of Oshii’s intertwining of mythology and technology to reach an “awakened” state.

Oshii makes a quite critical deviation from Shirow’s original manga when Kusanagi is given a new body after she has merged with the Puppet Master to become a new entity. In the manga, Batou secures a rather androgynous body for Kusanagi, and he is surprised when Kusanagi, in the new body, tells him that the body is actually male. In the film of *Ghost in the Shell*, Kusanagi’s new body is that of a young girl. Kusanagi’s maintenance of her female sex is important because of the religious connotations inherent in the female body in Japan. Teigo Yoshida shows how women in Japanese religion can be and have been portrayed as alternately polluted or sacred, depending on context.³⁰ In the film, Oshii plays with these notions of religious femininity. In the very first scene, Kusanagi attributes the static in her thought reception to the fact that she is having her period. The viewer knows that, as Kusanagi is a cyborg, this cannot be the case and she must be joking. Nonetheless, this serves to mark Kusanagi as feminine, as menstruation is a very powerful symbol of womanhood. Blood of any kind is seen as polluting in Japanese Shintō beliefs, and this idea carried over into Japanese Buddhism as well, generating the concept of the Pool of Blood Hell.³¹ Pollution is alluded to again in the climax of the film, when Kusanagi

symbolically “gives birth” to the offspring that was a result of her merger with the Puppet Master. (The exact details of what constitute these offspring are never made clear in the film.) Giving birth is an activity often viewed as impure in Japanese culture, but as Yoshida indicates, it also can be seen as sacred. The fact that Kusanagi is a cyborg also sets her apart, not necessarily within the world of *Ghost in the Shell*, but within Japanese culture, as there is a strong Shintō-based taboo against scarring the body in any way³²; Kusanagi’s cyborg body is nothing if not altered and scarred. Yet at the end of the film, it is Kusanagi who transcends her previous existence, while still retaining her female sex. In traditional Japanese Buddhism, “[t]he idea that women could not attain buddhahood has been around since ancient times, and so the theory of *henjonanshi* (metamorphosis of woman into man) was created in order to enable women to attain buddhahood by taking on the form of a man.”³³ Thus it is important that Kusanagi keep her original sex during her metamorphosis into a different type of being because it goes against the traditional Japanese Buddhist idea that a woman has to be re-born as a man before she can reach enlightenment.

Ideas from Christian theology are central to Kusanagi’s quest as well. When the Puppet Master tells her, “For now we see through a glass, darkly,” this quotation from Corinthians indicates Kusanagi’s impending freedom from the constraints of Section 9. By using such a quote, the Puppet Master is telling Kusanagi that her way will soon become clear and that they will soon see each other “face to face,” as the remainder of the quote says. The chapter of Paul’s first epistle to the Corinthians from which the quotation is taken is on God’s gift of love, and by using it the Puppet Master is professing its own love for Kusanagi. The Corinthians chapter ends with the words, “There are in the end three things that last: faith, hope, and love, and the greatest of these is love.” The Puppet Master’s gift of love enables Kusanagi to extricate herself from her bonds as a cyborg worker and to mature as an individual. As she leaves Batou’s safe house, Kusanagi tells him what preceded the Puppet Master’s original quote. Through the odd manifestation of the Puppet Master’s love for her, Kusanagi is able to put behind

her the “childish” governmental infighting she dealt with as an operative of Section 9, freeing her to explore more philosophical issues concerning the nature of self.

Kusanagi’s merger with the Puppet Master helps her free herself from the hierarchy of Section 9 and the confinement of her previous body. The presence of this hierarchy is shown as being essential to Kusanagi’s concept of self as well as its potential downfall through her cyborg body. Although Kusanagi “inhabits” her body, it belongs to the government, thereby ensuring her obedience. Her body serves as her own prison, ensnared by the constant potential for observation. Yet she does not fight directly against this force, but rather discovers a way around it, a way to subvert it. By merging with the Puppet Master, Kusanagi discards the need for her previous, government-owned body and is free to pursue whatever course of action or existential quest on which she may choose to embark.

Thus, through the concept of the cyborg, Oshii can critique the nature of work in the modern capitalist society. Such critiques are not new in cyberpunk science fiction—questions about the nature of work form the backbone of Gibson’s *Neuromancer*. Says Heather Hicks, “William Gibson’s novels are full of cyborgs whose technological components have transformed their lives into pure work. . . . they have passed from an existence in which they live, to one in which they function—in which they *work*.”³⁴ In *Patlabor*, the robot Labors did the actual work of constructing engineering marvels like the Babylon Project. However, in *Ghost in the Shell*, the worker has moved from inside the machine (contained, yet still separate) to becoming the machine itself. At the same time, one’s very existence (at least for those like Kusanagi and Batou) entails being forced to perform work about which one has no choice. The meaning of life has become the meaning of work. This idea continues to mirror previous thoughts in science fiction cyborg films. As Hicks points out: “The very euphemisms for cyborg death in *Bladerunner* [sic] and the *Terminator* films imply living is the equivalent of working in the ontology of the cyborg. If to be ‘retired’ or ‘terminated’ is to die, must not working be the entire extent of life?”³⁵

Oshii's solution to this central problem is not to divorce technology from the body, however, but to rethink the relationships between the two. The new Kusanagi at the end of *Ghost in the Shell* still has a cyborg body; however, she has slipped the bonds that previously held her in place, tying her to the government and Section 9.

The idea of the cyborg—the fusion of the body and technology in both real and conceptual ways—has become central in some modern academic thought. Beginning with Donna Haraway's seminal essay "A Cyborg Manifesto," the idea of the cyborg as a potentially liberating force has sparked much debate. Says Haraway: "Cyborg imagery can suggest a way out of the maze of dualisms in which we have explained our bodies and our tools to ourselves. This is a dream not of a common language, but of a powerful infidel heteroglossia."³⁶ While an in-depth discussion of cyborg theory is beyond the scope of this book, the concept of the cyborg as a radical method to find freedom from domination is one that resonates throughout *Ghost in the Shell*. Through the diversity of life created by the merger of Kusanagi and the Puppet Master, the two beings are trying to create something akin to the "powerful infidel heteroglossia." (This idea is also portrayed in more symbolic form in the destruction of the towering Ark of the Babylon Project in the first *Patlabor* film.) Although Kusanagi's cyborgness initially inscribes her within circles of power beyond her control, had she not been a cyborg, she would not have been able to slip these bonds and the additional restraints of society.

Through Kusanagi's conscious decisions (her quest for a real identity, not one merely assigned to her based on her status in the structure of Section 9, and her choice to merge with the Puppet Master), she creates a new form of life. This being possesses a fuller concept of self than Kusanagi did previously, as she worked solely at the command of the governmental structure. Although she was powerful, she was not powerful for herself, but was rather a pawn of the government and bureaucracy. Kusanagi was confined by the technology of the body, but through the technology of the Puppet Master she is able to slip the shackles of her imprisonment. One can infer

that this new life-form will no longer “see through a glass darkly,” but finally may be able to see clearly.

As a film, *Ghost in the Shell* occupies an interesting position in the science fiction genre as being a Japanese film that bridges the gap between two Western films, *Blade Runner* (dir. Ridley Scott, 1982) and *The Matrix* (dir. Andy and Lana Wachowski, 1999). *Ghost in the Shell* can be seen as restating a number of the story elements from *Blade Runner*, such as a questioning of the nature of humanity, the fallibility of memory (including the use of photographs to supplant memory), the use of a not-quite human protagonist trying to discover who s/he is while solving a case. As Livia Monnet writes, “[T]he many visual and diagetetic correspondences between *Ghost in the Shell* and *Blade Runner* indicate that Oshii’s anime has a conscious agenda of remediating Ridley Scott’s cult film, and that an intermedial conceptual fusion occurs between the two films.”³⁷ That Oshii would incorporate elements of Scott’s work is hardly surprising—in fact, he had already done so in the *Patlabor* OVA episode “It’s Called Amnesia” he had written. According to Napier, *Blade Runner* “was important not only to him but has undeniably influenced many Japanese animators.”³⁸ By incorporating such elements, Oshii reformulates and comments on the earlier film, adding an element of history to his already multilayered film. Similarly, *The Matrix* fuses specific elements from *Ghost in the Shell* into its own storyline. This was in fact one of the original goals of the Wachowski[s] when they set out to make their film. Said *Matrix* producer Joel Silver, “The Wachowski brothers showed me *Ghost in the Shell*. They showed me what they wanted to do with that type of action and photography, and try to make it with real people, with real actors. . . .”³⁹ From the way in which the opening credits were created to specific scenes that were referenced (such as a chase through a marketplace that includes exploding watermelon), *The Matrix* contains many references to Oshii’s film, yet succeeds in fashioning its own unique cinematic style.⁴⁰ It is appropriate that *Ghost in the Shell* should be an influence on such a landmark American film—after all, modern Japanese animation and comics were originally inspired by the cartoons of Disney and the Fleischer brothers

(most famous for their large-eyed creation Betty Boop). Oshii's film thus serves as a link in the continual fashioning and refashioning of global popular culture.

Since the film's release in 1995, more media have come into existence that explore the world of *Ghost in the Shell*. These include video games, novels, and more manga, and I have discussed these in detail earlier. In addition, in 2004 Oshii directed an animated sequel to *Ghost in the Shell* called *Innocence*, which I analyze in chapter 9. Of particular interest is the fact that in 2008, Oshii revamped his original film for a release called *Ghost in the Shell 2.0*. Although the essence of the film remained, the new version reimaged a number of scenes with updated CG animation, in addition to adjusting the overall color palette and remastering the sound track. In an interesting touch, the voice of the Puppet Master in *2.0* was no longer male; it was played by Yoshiko Sakakibara (who played *Urusei Yatsura: Only You's* Elle and *Patlabor's* Shinobu Nagumo, among many other roles). Although the new sound track improved upon the original sound effects, the new CG did not mesh well with the earlier animation. Altogether, *Ghost in the Shell 2.0* was probably an unnecessary upgrade, with its only purpose being to bring more attention to the director's work in advance of the release of *The Sky Crawlers*.

Like Kusanagi, Oshii was able to find his own form of freedom through the film. The international acclaim of *Ghost in the Shell* boosted his reputation as a director, allowing him more choice and flexibility in pursuing his artistic visions. According to Oshii, thanks to the international success of the film, "It's much easier to get money for projects now. As for myself, I haven't changed at all. Just like always, I make the things I want to make."⁴¹

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21. Oshii, e-mail to the author.

CHAPTER 4

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5. Horn, "At the Carpenter Center," 15. Chapter 5

CHAPTER 5

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8. Amos Wong, "Inside Production I.G.," *Newtype USA* 2, no. 4 (April 2003): 30.
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25. Rayns, "Game Master," 28–29.
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27. Oshii, e-mail to the author.
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CHAPTER 6

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